ELSTE Data science

Some concept of Python coding and statistical inference

Sébastien Biass

sebastien.biasse@unige.ch

Earth Sciences

Stéphane Guerrier

Stephane.Guerrier@unige.ch

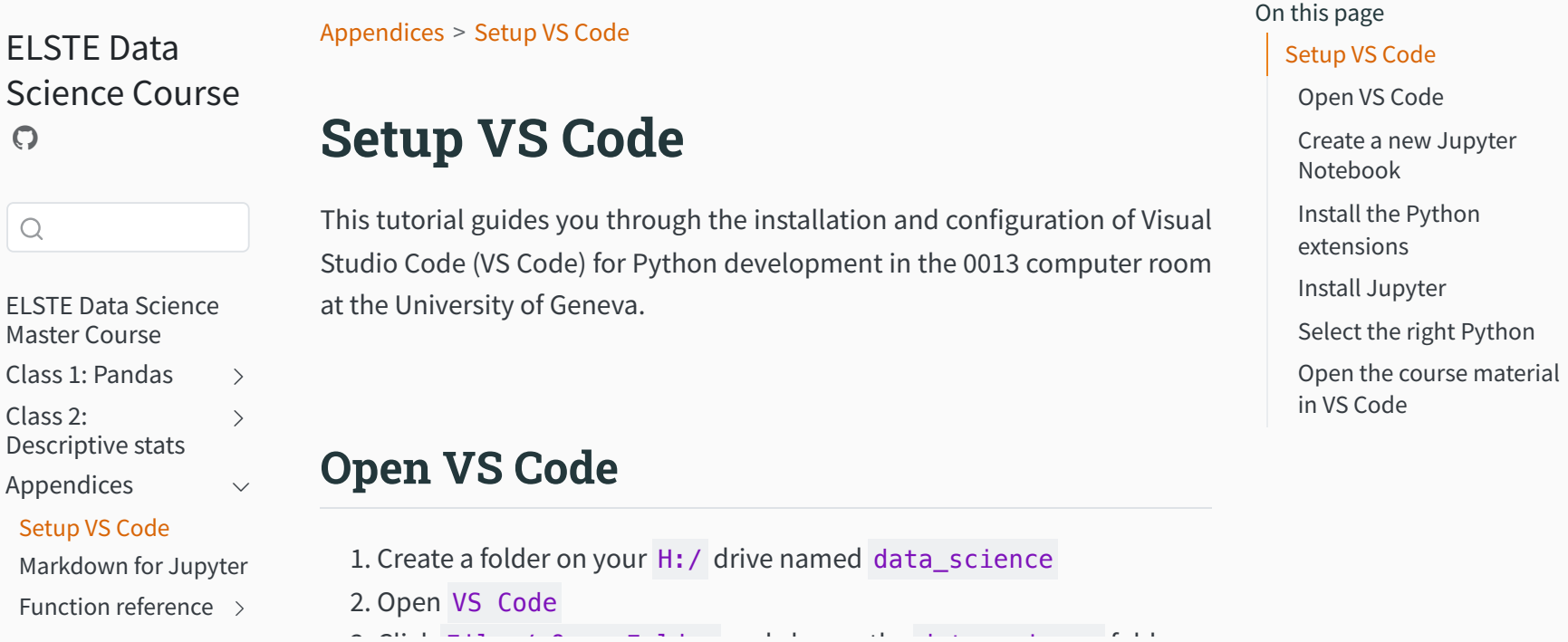
Earth Sciences

Pharmaceutical Sciences

October 14, 2026

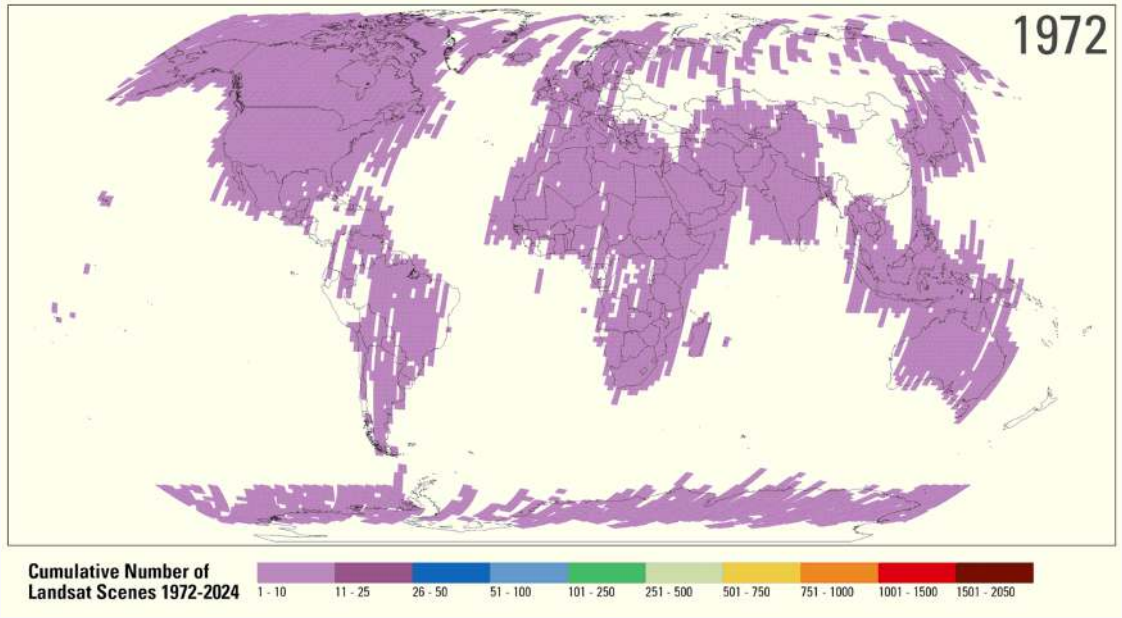
Get ready

- Go to https://elste-master.github.io/Data-Science/
  - → **Download slides:** Class 1 > Overview
  - → **Setup VS Code:** Appendices > Setup VS Code



Why this class? (1/2)

Data deluge: The big EO data landscape



- **Landsat:**
  - → Download: 53 images/day (2001) - 220’000 images/day (2017)
  - → 5 million images of the Earth surface → > 5 PB
- **ESA Sentinel 1 & 2 →** 4.6TB /daily!

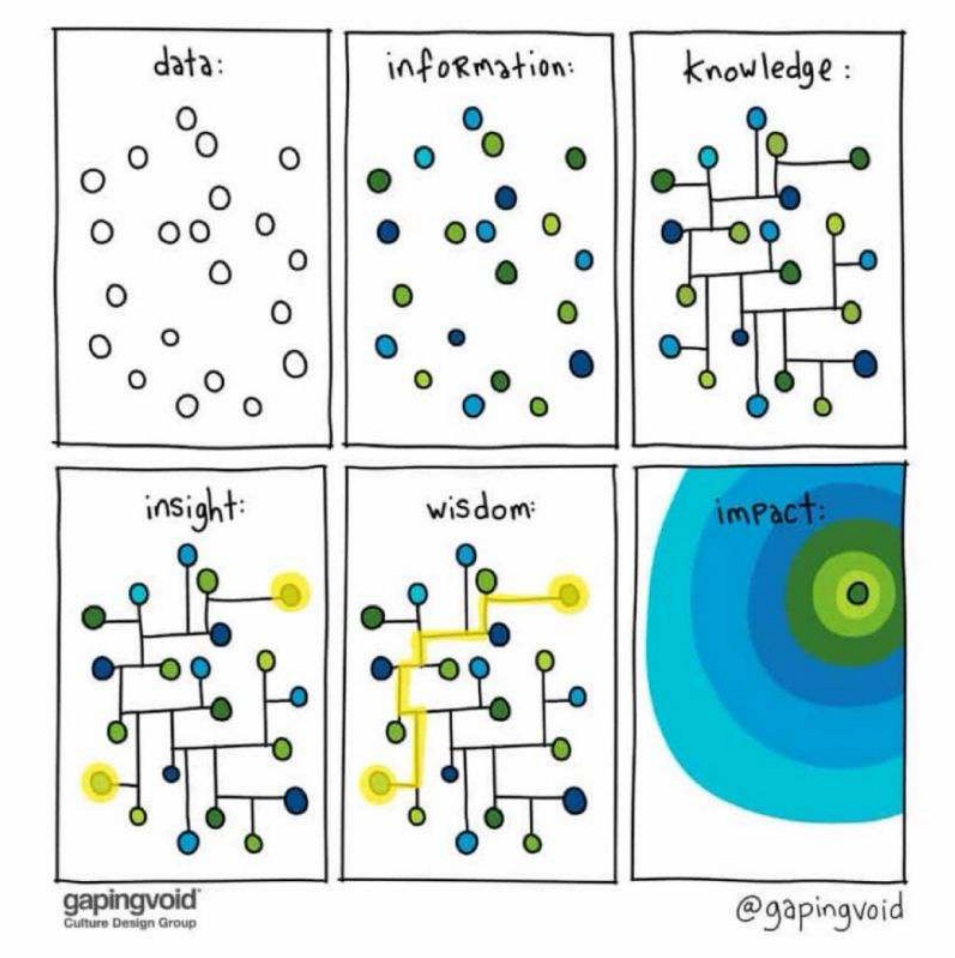
Why this class? (2/2)

As scientists, we are exposed to:

- Increasing computational power/facilities
- Increasing amount of data

How do we make sense of it all?

- Scientific coding → gateway to scientific data analysis
- Data science → extracting meaningful infomation and insights from data



What is data science

Wikipedia

> *Data science is an interdisciplinary academic field that uses statistics, scientific computing, scientific methods, processing, scientific visualization, algorithms and systems to extract or extrapolate knowledge from [...] data.*

National Institutes of Standards and Technology

> *The field that combines domain expertise, programming skills, and knowledge of mathematics and statistics to extract meaningful insights from data.*

Class schedule

- **Fall part at UNIGE**: 6 × 3-h long sessions
- **Assistants**: Sofia Hernandez Castro, Henry Hoult
- **Format**: Theory, live coding and exercises

October 14 and 21

- **Seb** → Exploratory data analysis

October 28, November 4 and 11

- **Stéphane** → Inference

November 18

- Question session + exam

Class objectives

- Scientific coding and stats often appear daunting
- True, there can be a steep learning curve

Objectives

- **Not** to make you and expert developer / statistician **but**
  - → Motivate scientific reasoning
  - → Develop statistical thinking

Get involved!!!

We want this class to be useful for your research!

Try to contextualise the course material to **your research**:

- Do you already have your own datasets you could bring to class?
- Can you use the course to formulate new research questions?
- Do you know any open-access datasets relevant to your fields?

  → If not, can you find some for the next weeks?

Why coding?

Motivations (1/6)

- **Example**: A common - but unnecessarily complicated - workflow of many specialised softwares



- **Objective**: Integrate full research workflow in an environment supporting all tasks



Motivations (2/6)

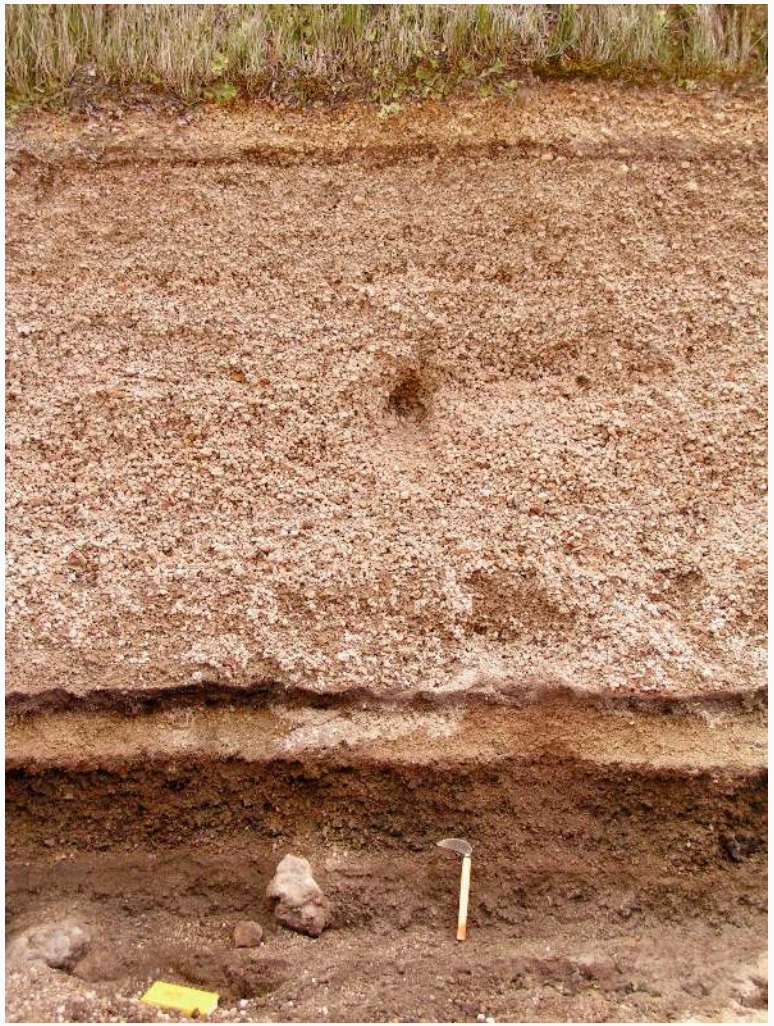
Motivation 1: Automation

Cotopaxi volcano

- Reconstructing eruption source parameters (ESP) from tephra deposits

  → *How do different measurement methods influence ESP estimates?*

- 40 outcrops
- ~10 samples per outcrop
- ~7 measurement methods per sample



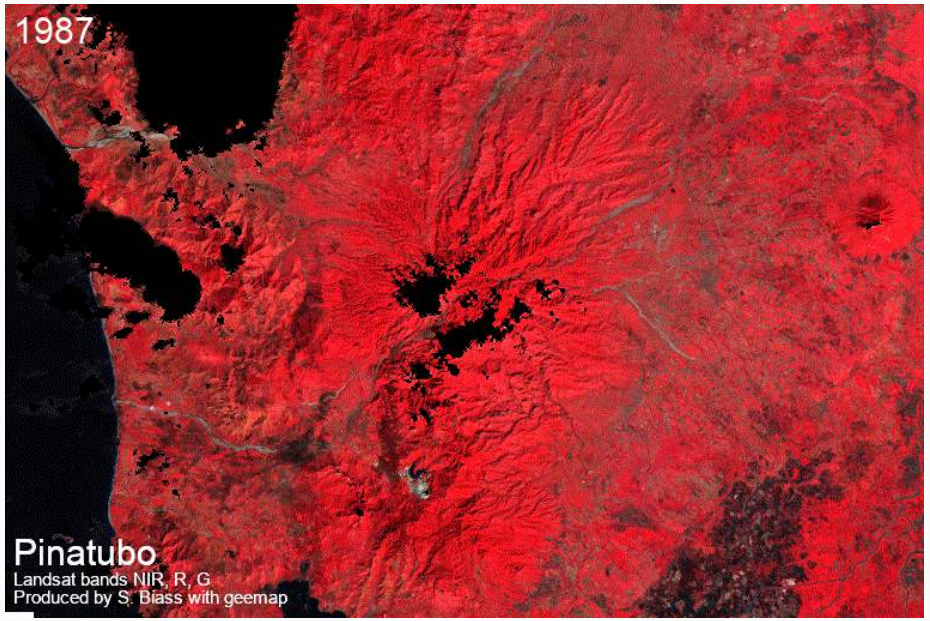
Motivations (3/6)

Motivation 2: Data analysis

Example 1: Exploit catalogues of big Earth Observation data

- **Revisit big EO catalogues to infer new knowledge**

  → *What controls the impact and recovery of vegetation following eruptions?*

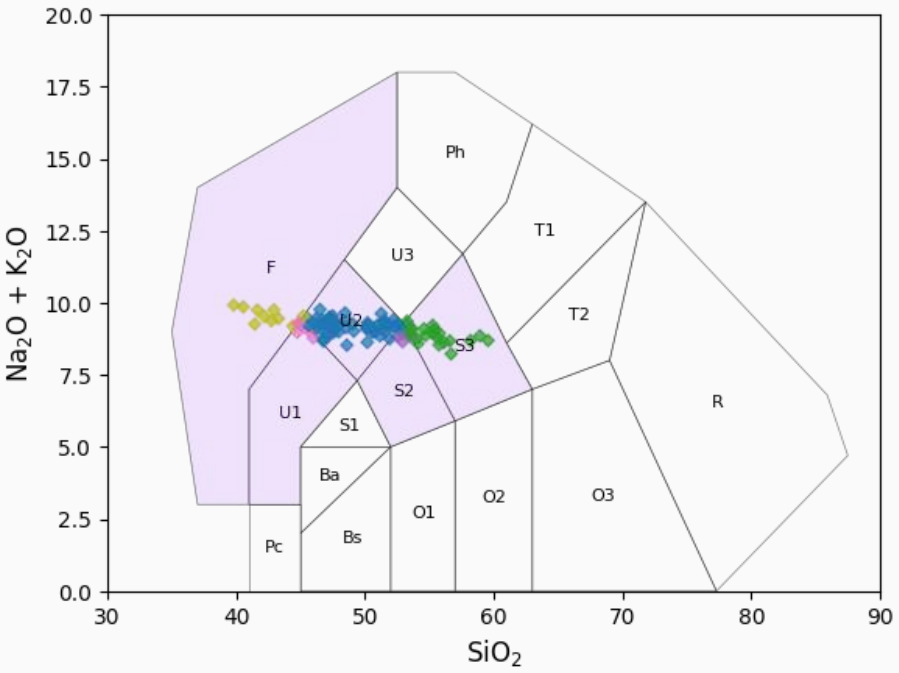


Motivations (4/6)

Motivation 2: Data analysis

Example 2: Streamline global geochemical analyses

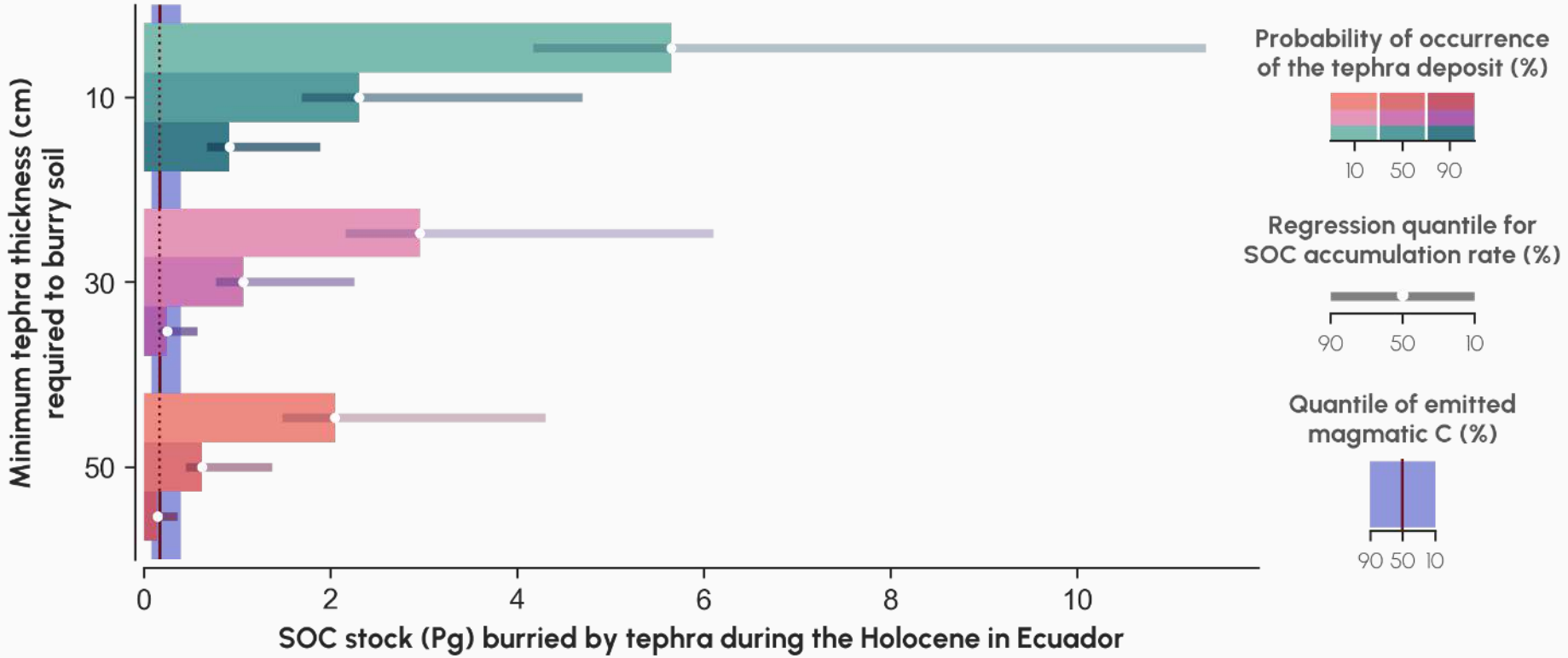
- **Access global databases**
  - → e.g., *Georock* database
- **Automatic dedicated analyses/plots**
  - → e.g., *TAS* diagrams and classification using `pyrolite`



Motivations (5/6)

Motivation 3: Visualisation

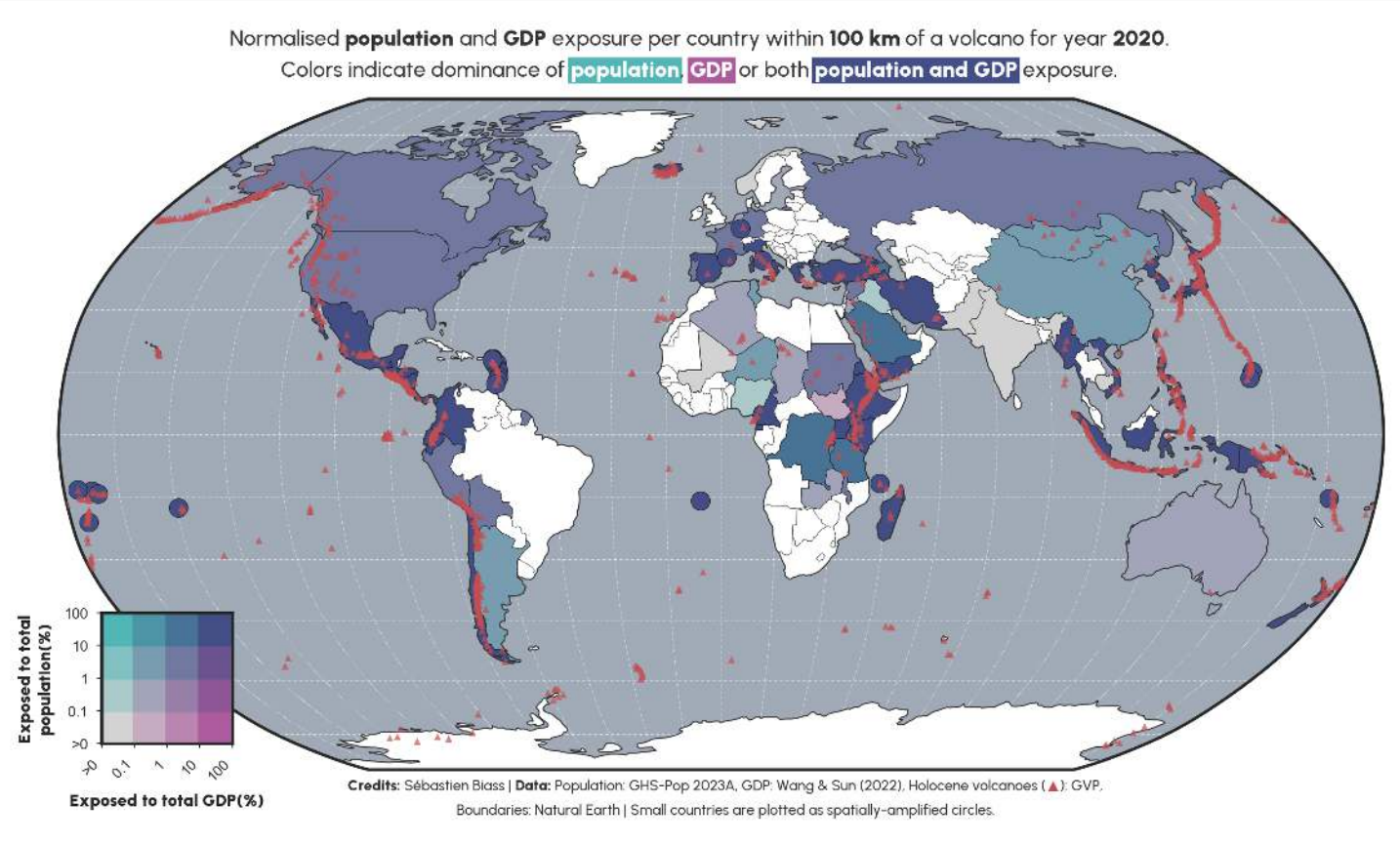
Example 1: In volcanically-active regions, soil burial after explosive eruptions capture more carbon that they emit.



Motivations (6/6)

Motivation 3: Visualisation

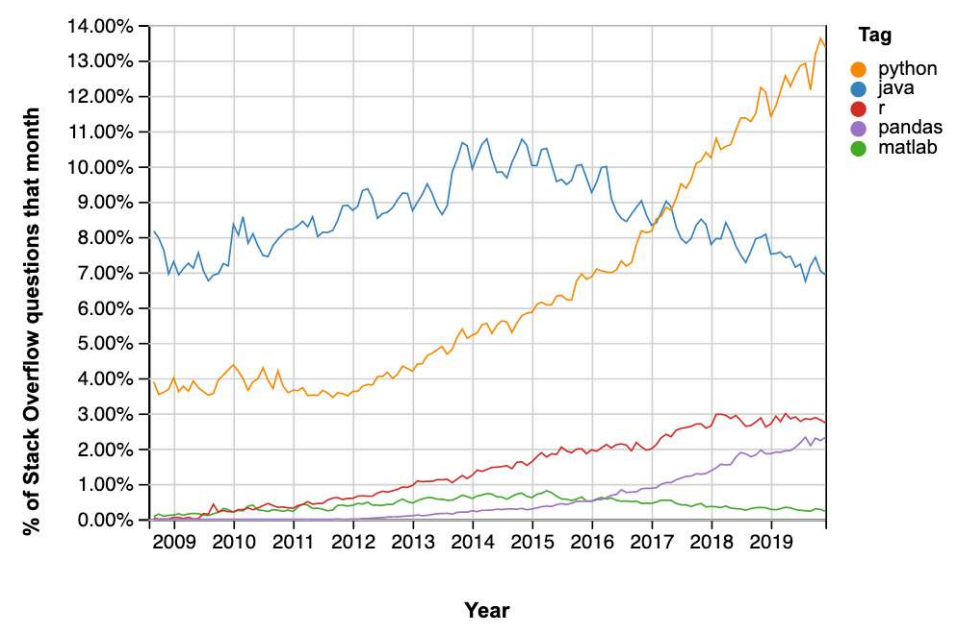
Example 2: In Small Island States, ≥90% of population and GDP is exposed to volcanic hazards.



Why Python?

Python's advantages [1]

1. **Free**
2. **Open source**
   - Not dependent on any company
   - Large online community
3. **Old** → stable (started in 1991)
4. **Very** popular in science
5. Relatively easy to learn



1. Inspired by the School of Oceanography at University of Washington

What is Python

High-level computing language

- Compiled → doesn't directly speak to the computer, but is *interpreted* by another language
  - → Usually slower, but much, much easier to use!

Modular

- Python is composed of a *core* of functions complemented by wide ecosystem of specialized packages for specific tasks
  - → A function is a bit of code to perform a **specific task**
  - → A module is a collection of **functions**
  - → A package is composed by multiple **modules**

An example of packages, modules and functions

In the code below, we first load the necessary packages and libraries:

- `matplotlib` is the main **visualisation** package used in Python
- `pyplot` is a module of `matplotlib` that provides easy-to-use functions for **plotting** data
- `figure` is a function of `pyplot` and is the main function to prepare a plot

```
1 # Import the packages and modules
2 from matplotlib import pyplot as plt
3 # Set up a figure for plotting
4 plt.figure(...)
```

How to use Python

Option 1: Your own computer

- Requires some setup
- No internet connection required
- Slow if computer is slow
- All data stored on your own computer

> Try this tutorial

Option 2: In the cloud → Google Collab

- No setup required
- No internet connection required
- Decent speed, free as long as Google says it is free
- All data stored in the cloud

How to run Python

3 main ways to run Python…

1. Run Python `.py` scripts from the command line → *deprecated*
2. Run blocks of code from within a Python `.py` script using `ipykernel` → **similar behaviour to R/Matlab**
3. Use **Jupyter Notebooks** in `.ipynb` files

…in two different environments

1. Dedicated software: VSCode, PyCharm, Spyder
2. Web browser: JupyterLab

How to approach coding

Python as a natural language

Natural language	Python	Example
Noun	Object or variable	`df`
Verb	Function or method	`mean()`, `sort_values()`
Complement	Target variable	`"altitude"`
Adverb	Argument specifying how	`ascending=False`
Sentence	Instruction	`df.sort_values(...)`

```
1 df.sort_values("altitude", ascending=False)
```



Python checks the grammar of your code. **You** must check the scientific meaning of the sentence.

From a sentence to a sequence of tasks

Task	Questions to ask
Load	Where are the data? How do I read them?
Inspect	What do the rows, columns and values represent?
Select / filter	Which columns and observations do I need?
Transform	What should I sort, recode or calculate?
Summarise / analyse	What quantity or relationship answers my question?
Visualise / export	How should I show or save the result?

Today’s plans

Get started

- Go to https://elste-master.github.io/Data-Science/
  - → **Setup VS Code:** Appendices > Setup VS Code
  - → Follow Class 1

How to do it?

- Create a Jupyter Notebook
- Copy & paste code fragment → make sure you **understand** what you are doing!
  - → Use the documentation / **cheat sheets** / **companion course**
- Document your code with **Markdown**

Today's objectives

4 modules:

1. Data structure
2. Querying data
3. Filtering data
4. Data operations

→ We expect you to know how to get started with Python / Jupyter notebook, shout if you are lost

Start coding!

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